From Songlines to the Cloud

Episode 4: How America Lost Geography

[Cold open]

In 2002, the National Geographic Society commissioned a survey of young adults, aged eighteen to twenty-four, in nine countries. The United States came second to last, ahead of only Mexico.

The survey went into the field as the country was moving toward war with Iraq. Only thirteen percent of young Americans could find Iraq on a map. Seventeen percent could find Afghanistan. Half could find New York State. And eleven percent could not find the United States.

Four years later, the Society asked again, with a different set of maps. After three years of war, sixty-three percent of young Americans still couldn't find Iraq on a map of the Middle East. Eighty-eight percent couldn't find Afghanistan on a map of Asia. A third couldn't find Louisiana, just months after Hurricane Katrina. And fewer than thirty percent thought it was important to know where the countries in the news actually are.

[Beat]

It's easy to laugh at numbers like that, or to roll your eyes at twenty-year-olds. I'd rather ask a different question. How does the most powerful country on Earth, after sixty years of global engagement, end up there? Because it wasn't an accident. It was a series of decisions, and most of them were made long before those young people were born.

[Theme]

This is *From Songlines to the Cloud*. I'm Paul. In the last episode, geography built itself a home in universities and schools across Europe and America. In this one, we watch the United States take that home apart, piece by piece, over about a hundred years. If you work in American education, some of this will feel very familiar.

* * *

The first decision came early, in 1916, and it came from a committee.

That year, the National Education Association's Committee on Social Studies, part of a larger commission reorganizing American secondary education, issued its report. It's the document that established "social studies" as the umbrella for school subjects about human society. And it framed the whole field around one goal: good citizenship. Not disciplinary knowledge. Citizenship.

In the plan the committee laid out, geography became one strand of a junior-high social studies sequence, sitting alongside history and civics. It was no longer a subject in its own right. Two years later came the Cardinal Principles report of 1918, and the historian Diane Ravitch's verdict on it is blunt: "Neither history or geography survived as a subject; both were submerged into the new field of the 'social studies.'"

To be fair, other historians caution that the change wasn't sudden. It unfolded over the 1920s, '30s and '40s, through so-called "fusion" courses. But the direction was never in doubt. By the mid-1970s, only about nine percent of American students in grades seven through twelve were enrolled in a geography course. By 2015, only seventeen states required a stand-alone geography course in middle school, and only ten in high school.

I lead a social sciences department myself, so I'm not here to bash social studies. Integration can be powerful. But "integrated" has a way of meaning that the subject without a champion quietly disappears. In American schools, for most of the twentieth century, that subject was geography.

* * *

The second decision was made at Harvard, in 1948, and it's one of the strangest stories in the history of American higher education.

Harvard had a geography program that had been growing, modestly but optimistically, through the 1940s. In 1948, it was suddenly shut down. The press called the fight that followed an "academic war over the field of geography," and nearly forty years later the geographer Neil Smith used that phrase as the title of his definitive reconstruction of what happened, built from university archives and dozens of interviews.

The blow was double. First, there was who did it: Harvard, with all its prestige. And second, in the course of the closure, Harvard's president suggested that geography simply wasn't an appropriate subject for a university. The famous version of the line, attributed to President James Conant, is that "geography is not a university subject." I should say clearly that we have that line second-hand. It comes from Smith's archival work, not from anything Conant published. But the sentiment, from the president of Harvard, was devastating.

So what actually happened? Smith's big revelation was the role of a man named Isaiah Bowman. Bowman was president of Johns Hopkins, a former director of the American Geographical Society, and the most politically powerful geographer in America. And Smith found that he "appears to have been more instrumental than is generally realized" in killing the department. He advised Conant, and he had little regard for Harvard's program.

[Beat]

Let that sink in. The most powerful geographer in America helped to close geography at America's most powerful university.

The trigger was mundane: a dispute over promotions inside Harvard's Division of Geological Sciences. A geologist named Marland Billings wrote letters questioning whether human geography mattered and arguing that the money would be better spent on geology. Those letters set off the review that ended the department.

And there was something uglier underneath. Accounts building on Smith's research report that the rumored homosexuality of the department's chair, Derwent Whittlesey, and the promotion case of his partner, Harold Kemp, were a complicating factor, and that Bowman's hostility had a homophobic edge. Later accounts add postwar money problems, a faculty committee that couldn't agree on what geography's core actually was, and the anxieties of the early Red Scare.

Geographers on both sides of the Atlantic protested. In 1951 the *Harvard Crimson* wrote that the university had "emasculated its geography department, quickly, silently," and called for it to be brought back. It wasn't. The French geographer Jean Gottmann later called the closure "a terrible blow" from which American geography "has never completely recovered." And Neil Smith asked the question that matters most: why was geography "so vulnerable in the first place"?

Harvard did not grant another geography degree for roughly seventy years.

* * *

Other private universities followed. Each had its own local reasons, and those stories are still under-researched, but the pattern is hard to miss.

Pennsylvania's department, which had been merged into the Wharton School, closed in 1963. Yale's program lingered, in one description, "near death" until 1967. Yale, you'll remember, had been the home of Ellsworth Huntington, the arch-determinist with the climate map that peaked in New Haven.

At the University of Michigan, the Board of Regents voted unanimously in June 1981 to discontinue geography, effective a year later, after a review stretching over several years. The administration cited the economic climate, the department's scholarly quality and productivity, and its "lack of centrality" to the curriculum. The researchers who've studied that case describe administrators under austerity asking which disciplines were "least essential." And many at Michigan, they found, had been ready to answer "geography" since at least the mid-1970s. Michigan was the first of a string of major closures in the early-to-mid 1980s.

Then came 1986. Columbia's department, "easily the most prodigious of the Ivy League," ended for lack of enrollment and funding. And at the University of Chicago, the very first geography department in the country, ranked number one in the nation back in 1925, was demoted to a "Committee on Geographic Studies." Northwestern's once-prominent department was also disbanded sometime in the mid-1980s; the exact date isn't well documented.

Put it together and the top departments of 1925, at Harvard, Yale, Columbia and Clark, had either disappeared or declined sharply. Geography survived, mainly at public and land-grant universities. But it had lost its foothold among the elite.

* * *

Why? The causes braid together, and we've met most of them already.

Environmental determinism had tainted the discipline's scientific reputation. Its racism and its empirical failures left the whole field, as one scholar put it, "long plagued" by the association. Then Hartshorne's regional paradigm, which dominated exactly when the closures began, presented geography as descriptive, synthetic, about the uniqueness of places. That's a perfectly defensible intellectual position. It's also very hard to defend in front of a budget committee. At Harvard, the committee couldn't agree on what geography's core was. At Michigan, administrators judged it not central. And on top of all that, personal politics: Bowman's interventions, the fight with geology over resources, the homophobia around Whittlesey.

And here's the paradox. All this happened precisely as the Second World War and the Cold War were making knowledge of other lands and peoples more important to the United States than ever before. And it happened while geography was doing perfectly well in Britain.

There's a vicious circle here, too, that anyone in education will recognize. Weak geography in schools means few students arrive at university wanting to study it. Low enrollments justify closing departments. Closed departments make the subject even less visible in schools. Round and round.

* * *

From the late 1980s, the results became measurable.

In 1988, Gallup ran a survey for the National Geographic Society: nearly eleven thousand adults in nine countries, each asked to locate sixteen places on a blank world map. Swedes did best, with an average of about eleven and a half. Americans averaged eight point six, ahead of only Italy and Mexico. And American eighteen-to-twenty-four-year-olds averaged under seven, a lower average than any other age group in any country surveyed. The United States was the only country where the youngest adults did worse than the oldest. And they scored lower than young Americans had in a comparable survey back in 1947. A follow-up in the Soviet Union the next year found young Soviets well ahead of young Americans, though Gallup concluded that both publics showed "an astonishing lack of awareness of the world around them."

A fairness caveat, because it matters: geographic ignorance isn't uniquely American. One 1995 study of sketch maps put American university students near the global average. But in these big polls, the United States consistently ranked at or near the bottom of the wealthy countries.

Then there's the National Assessment of Educational Progress, the Nation's Report Card. NAEP assessed geography in 1994, 2001, 2010, 2014 and 2018. In 2014, twenty-seven percent of eighth-graders scored at or above Proficient. In 2018, twenty-five percent. And the 2018 average was statistically no different from 1994. A quarter of a century of flat, low achievement.

Then, in July 2019, even the measurement stopped. The National Assessment Governing Board dropped geography from the testing schedule through about 2030, along with economics and the arts, citing budget constraints. The National Council for the Social Studies called it "a devastating blow to our students." Its president said the field had been "completely blindsided."

[Beat]

We didn't fix the fever. We threw away the thermometer.

* * *

Federal policy captured the whole paradox in a single line item.

At the 1989 education summit in Charlottesville, geography was named among the core subjects in the new national goals. Then, in 2001, the No Child Left Behind Act listed geography as one of nine "core academic subjects." And it was

the only one of the nine with no dedicated federal funding stream. In fiscal 2004, federal funding for history education was roughly a hundred million dollars. For geography, it was zero.

Core, in other words. And funded at nothing. With testing and money focused elsewhere, the geography-education literature argues that in most public schools, geography as a separate subject effectively ceased to exist.

It wasn't for lack of effort. The 1980s and '90s brought a real reform wave. In 1984 the *Guidelines for Geographic Education* introduced the Five Themes: location, place, human–environment interaction, movement, and regions. If you trained as a teacher in the United States, there's a fair chance you can still recite them. National Geographic built a network of state geographic alliances for teachers, launched Geography Awareness Week, and in 1989 started the National Geography Bee, created in direct response to rising geographic illiteracy. In 1994, *Geography for Life* set out eighteen voluntary national standards, aiming to produce what it called "the geographically informed person."

The honest verdict? Those efforts rebuilt the frameworks and the teacher networks. Given the flat test scores and zero federal funding, they did not bring back geography as a stand-alone subject in most states.

* * *

The comparison with other countries is what makes this a choice rather than a fate.

In England, geography became a foundation subject of the National Curriculum under the 1988 Education Reform Act, compulsory to age fourteen, and it was never folded into social studies. It had its own dip in the early 2000s. Then a new school accountability measure, the English Baccalaureate, introduced in the 2010–11 school year, required a pass in history *or* geography, and the share of pupils taking geography at GCSE jumped from twenty-six percent in 2010 to thirty-six percent in 2014. For years, the Russell Group of universities listed geography at A-level as a "facilitating subject." And British universities kept their geography departments right through the decades when America's elite universities were closing theirs.

In Germany, geography, *Erdkunde*, is an independent and generally compulsory school subject. The German geography community even wrote its own national education standards, making geography the first school subject in Germany to have national standards developed outside the official framework of the states.

The United States was distinctive on three counts. It folded geography into social studies in 1916. It pushed it out of its elite universities between 1948 and 1986. And it funded it at zero in federal school policy. The survey gap is what those three decisions look like, measured.

* * *

That could be the end of the story. A discipline weakened by its own past, pushed out of the schools and the elite universities, its national assessment cancelled.

But it isn't the end, because while all of this was happening, something else was going on, and it came from a direction almost nobody expected. In the 1950s, in Seattle, a group of graduate students nicknamed the "space cadets" were dragging geography into statistics and computing. In Canada, a geographer had a chance conversation on an airplane. And Harvard, the very university that had closed geography in 1948, was about to open a laboratory that would help give birth to GIS.

Next time: the comeback.

I'm Paul. This has been *From Songlines to the Cloud*. Thanks for listening.

[Theme out]